padishah, the raja and his kin came to take their leave. Akbar was riding a musth elephant, ‘rushing in every direction’,[50] and causing havoc, presumably, while Bairam tried to hold court on his behalf. As the chaos increased and people fled, the elephant turned upon the Rajputs – who, unlike the rest of the court, remained in place. Akbar was impressed – the first of many times that he would be impressed by Rajput courage – impressed enough, in fact, to ask to know more about the raja. He did not know that he was enquiring after his future father-in-law, nor how their lives would intertwine until their very blood was one.

Five years would pass, however, before the two met again; five years in which Akbar would leave his childhood behind.

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Akbar’s inattention in court on the day the Rajputs were leaving – his active disruption of it, in fact – was clearly not uncommon. Abul Fazl expends a great deal of his ink, at this point, on expanding metaphors of the veil – here equivalent to the proverbial bushel under which Akbar was hiding his light.

It was the veil, therefore, that stopped Akbar from halting Hemu’s execution. At other times, he was living ‘within the veil of indifference’, ‘clad . . . in a garb of estrangement’, or ‘pretended not to notice’ – all this apparent distraction a guise to ‘test the powerful . . . under the veil of inattention’.

As always with Abul Fazl, there is a great deal of myth-making in the metaphor. The veil carried many political connotations. For one, as Azfar Moin writes, ‘The veiling of the face . . . was a mark of the awaited savior who had yet to manifest his true nature.’[51] It might also hint at a person, particularly a ruler, being a representative of God – conceived as pure light in Islamic theology. Thus, Harbans Mukhia tells of how the thirteenth-century sultan Balban, having declared himself God’s shadow, appeared in court with his face literally veiled, ‘lest even the shadow of the powerful light blind an onlooker’.

On the other hand, Abul Fazl’s enthusiasm for myth-making is matched by an equally fierce commitment to creating an accurate historical record. He wasn’t making it up: Akbar was distracted, but that doesn’t mean that Akbar wasn’t paying attention.